FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has the habit of setting very ambitious and challenging targets. Now, with the results of the general election a little over two months away, he has proclaimed a target of 370 seats for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—and a phenomenal "*char sau paar*" or 400-plus for the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). A battle cry that is resonating around the country. It constitutes a giant leap from the 303 and 352 seats the BJP and NDA totted up, respectively, in 2019 that some would say is just a morale-booster for the cadre. It does have a psychological effect all around, including on the Opposition and the electorate. Our cover story this issue takes a hard look at whether this stupendous number can be achieved, if at all. To reach this goal, the BJP will have to get nearly 50 per cent of the votes from India's nearly 970 million-strong electorate.

Beyond the slogans and the rhetoric, there are five key tactical areas the BJP is sharp-focused on. The first can be expressed as a motto—'Hold the Fortress'. That is, solidify the hold on geographical areas it already dominates and not let even an iota of slackness creep in. Across the Hindi heartland and down western India, there's a continuum of 13 states with a total of 327 seats that the BJP swept along with its allies in 2019, winning 296 seats and leaving only 31 for the Opposition. These are, in order of size, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Karnataka, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Haryana, Delhi, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh. The idea is to maximise gains wherever possible, and stamp out any chance of erosion across this mini-continent of support.



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Although the BJP dominated UP in the previous general election, the NDA still had 16 seats it did not win and where they have room to grow. It is also the sort of state where its dual allure goes down well—Ram and Roti. In terms of risk, it has to watch out in Maharashtra, Karnataka and Bihar. But they also spell opportunity as they are going as the major partner for the first time in Maharashtra and Bihar. The 2024 election presents a chance for the BJP to expand its footprint as a party and entrench itself as a dominant force in these states. Not coincidentally, these are also the states that have witnessed a long strategic thrust by the BJP.

Linking up with that is the second key tactic: Destroy the Opposition. This plays out through several modes, all carefully planned and ruthlessly executed. The gambit was used most dramatically in Maharashtra, where old-time ally Shiv Sena had deserted the BJP. First, the Sena was split; a year later, Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party too. The other script unfolded in Bihar like a magician's trick, with the very scriptwriter of Opposition unity, Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, switching camps in January. Woo, splinter, engineer defections, hold out the threat of central agencies and the BJP keeps the Opposition perennially confused and off-kilter. Recalcitrant leaders like Delhi's chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and former Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren find themselves cooling their heels in prison.

The idea everywhere is the same: do not let the I.N.D.I.A. bloc's votes coalesce. This makes eminent sense if one reads the state of play in another way. Out of the BJP's tally of 303 in 2019, it had won as many as 224 seats with over 50 per cent votes. These form the core zone of the BJP's fortress. That is, the Opposition can practically stop dreaming about them. It would take a massive vote swing of 5-10 per cent if it wishes to make a dent. The balance of narratives does not seem to favour that. That leaves 319 seats where the BJP has not been unshakeable, and its tactical to-do list is to push aggressively into these zones. Overall, the NDA had 45 per cent of the vote share in 2019 and the UPA (United Progressive Alliance) managed only 26 per cent. Now that the UPA has expanded into a somewhat rickety I.N.D.I.A. bloc, it will have to pool its votes and up its cumulative share to around 44 per cent to be in the game. The BJP's pinpointed strafing on Opposition positions is meant to preclude precisely that.

The BJP's third tactical focus fixes its gaze on prey further afield. Call it the Coromandel challenge. A whole arc from West Bengal in the east to most of the southern states make up either newly tilled fields or totally virgin areas. Enlarging its geographical footprint here is a long-held desire that may take a while to fully fructify. Bengal, where it got 18 out of 42 seats in 2019, is the only state where it has serious prospects of growth as the new No. 2 party. But even a small takehome from states like Odisha, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh adds up eventually and helps hedge against any potential erosion elsewhere. Moreover, tie-ups such as the one with Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party in Andhra Pradesh also help the allies grow in its company. Add to this extensive touring of the South by the prime minister, and you know the BJP sees electoral potential there. Every seat counts if the 400-plus target is to be achieved.

The fourth piece from the BJP's armoury is not a separate element. Rather, it is a condiment that flavours all other realms. This is its ideological Hindutva thrust. Here, many of the party's long-cherished objectives have been met and more are incubating. Article 370, the grand inauguration of the Ram temple, a legal wedge into Kashi's Gyanvapi masjid, the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and the first draft of the Uniform Civil Code from Uttarakhand—all hold a general appeal for their core voter. At the same time, winning Nitish over has meant blunting the caste census plank that I.N.D.I.A. was sharpening.

The last is hardly the least: Modi himself. All said and done, he still looms over the landscape as the ultimate trump card for the BJP. This is why it suits them to turn 2024 into a presidential-style campaign. By June 4, we will know how many from India's masses respond to the BJP's quest for 400-plus and get on to Modi's Ark.

(Aroon Purie)